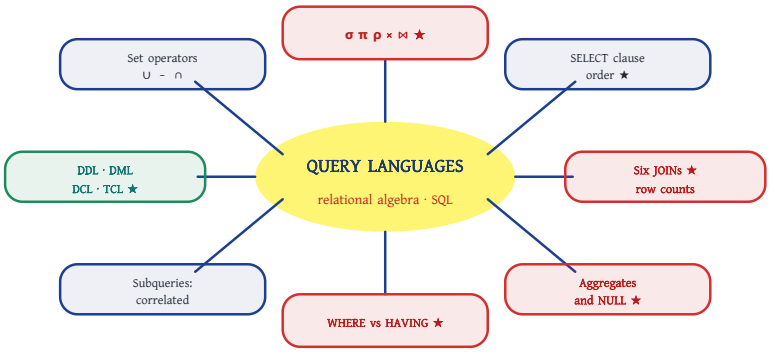
Query Languages: RA & SQL

Relational algebra · SQL command families · the six joins · aggregates, NULL & GROUP BY: exam-ready in 10 sheets



↑ the whole topic: red = high-yield, green = the practical side

Syllabus coverage

The Database Systems syllabus reads: "Concepts of database systems; Data Models: Entity-Relationship model, Relational model; **Query Languages: Relational algebra, SQL**; Constraints and triggers; Functional dependencies and normalization; File organization and data storage; Indexing: primary and secondary indexes, B+ trees, hash tables; Query optimization; ..." **This lesson takes the "Query Languages" clause only.** Constraints and triggers are one line further down the same line — they were covered with the data models; normalisation, indexing and transactions have their own lessons.

High-yield list

① σ filters **rows**, π chooses **columns**
② ρ renames; × pairs every row with every row
③ DDL · DML · DCL · TCL — four families
④ **DROP** kills structure; DELETE/TRUNCATE do not
⑤ WHERE filters **before** grouping, HAVING **after**
⑥ **COUNT(*)=5, COUNT(a)=3** on 1,NULL,3,NULL,5
⑦ AVG of 10,NULL,20 = **15**, never 10
⑧ NULL never equals anything in a join
⑨ 6 joins: INNER, LEFT, RIGHT, FULL, CROSS, SELF
⑩ σ ⇒ the WHERE clause; π ⇒ the SELECT list

Legend: **yellow** = key term · **red circle** = must-memorise · **purple** = memory trick · **red** = exam trap · **green** = worked example

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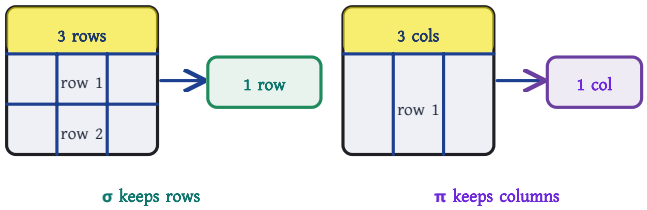
1 Relational Algebra (RA): the Eight Operators

Definition: **Relational algebra** is the **theoretical** language of queries: every request is written as a sequence of operations applied to relations, and the result of one step is the input of the next. It has **five primitive operations** (σ, π, ρ, ×, and the assignment) from which the rest — join, intersection, division — are derived. Every step returns a **relation**, so steps can be chained freely.

Operation	Symbol	What it does	Example
Selection	σ	keeps the **rows** that satisfy a condition	`σ salary>50000 (Emp)`
Projection	π	keeps the chosen **columns**; removes duplicates	`π name,salary (Emp)`
Union	∪	every tuple of both relations, once	`A ∪ B`
Set difference	−	tuples in A that are **not** in B	`A − B`
Intersection	∩	tuples present in both	`A ∩ B`
Cartesian product	×	**every row of A with every row of B**	`Emp × Dept`
Rename	ρ	renames a relation or an attribute	`ρ pay/salary (Emp)`
Join	⋈	product then selection — natural or θ	`Emp ⋈ Dept`

Derived operations: Everything that is not primitive is built from the five: **θ-join** = $\sigma_{A=B}(R \times S)$ · **natural join** = θ-join plus automatic removal of the duplicated join attribute · **intersection** = `A − (A − B)` · **rename** is primitive, but ρ is what makes a self-join legal.

Worked example ✍️ the set operators: `A = {1, 2, 3}`, `B = {3, 4}` → `A ∪ B = {1,2,3,4}` (**4**, the 3 appears once) · `A − B = {1,2}` · `A ∩ B = {3}` · `A × B` = **3 × 2 = 6** tuples, all distinct.
∪, ∩ and − need **union-compatible** relations (same attributes, same domains) and never repeat a tuple. The product needs **no** common attribute name — which is why ρ comes before `Students × Courses`.



a query is a chain: one relation feeds the next

read it inside out

σ narrows downwards, π narrows sideways

Memory trick: "Sigma picks rows, pi picks columns." σ is the letter you point at a *line* of a table with; π is used in a *list*. In SQL they are **WHERE** and **SELECT** — never the other way round.

Exam trap: **σ does not change the number of columns** and **π does not change the number of rows** (it may remove duplicates). "Which operator drops a column?" → **π**. "Which operator drops a row?" → **σ**. And **ρ changes nothing at all**: only the label.

2 RA Worked on the Students / Courses Database

Every RA question in an exam is asked about some concrete pair of relations. Learn these two and the symbol stops being abstract.

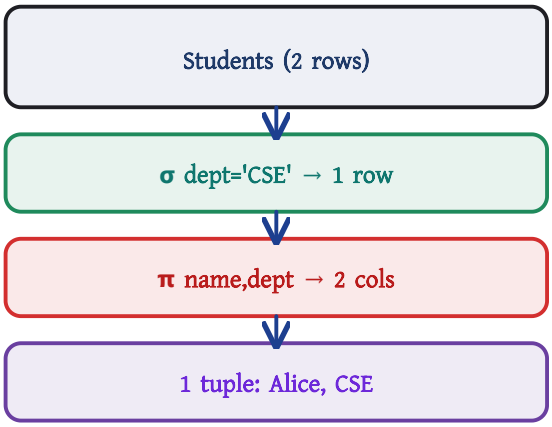
Students	id	name	dept
	1	Alice	CSE
	2	Bob	EEE
Courses	**cid**	**name**	
	C1	DBMS	
	C2	Algorithms	

RA query	Result
`σ dept='CSE'(Students)`	1 tuple: (1,Alice,CSE)
`π name (Students)`	2 tuples: Alice, Bob
`π dept (Students)`	2 tuples: CSE, EEE
`Students × Courses`	2 × 2 = **4** tuples

Exam trap: The Cartesian product of *these two* relations is **4** tuples, not 2 and not 3: **rows × rows**. In general a product of *m* rows and *n* rows gives *m* × *n* rows — a 3-row and a 3-row relation give **9**.

Worked example 1 ✍️: "List the name and department of every CSE student."
RA: `π name,dept (σ dept='CSE'(Students))`
SQL: `SELECT name, dept FROM Students WHERE dept='CSE';`
Read the RA **inside out**: the innermost bracket is evaluated first, so σ filters and π then trims the columns.

Worked example 2 ✍️: "Show every student paired with every course."
RA: `π name,cname (Students × ρ cname/name(Courses))`
SQL: `SELECT s.name, c.name FROM Students s, Courses c;`
ρ is **mandatory**: after the product both relations have an attribute called *name*, and a relation may not carry two attributes of the same name.



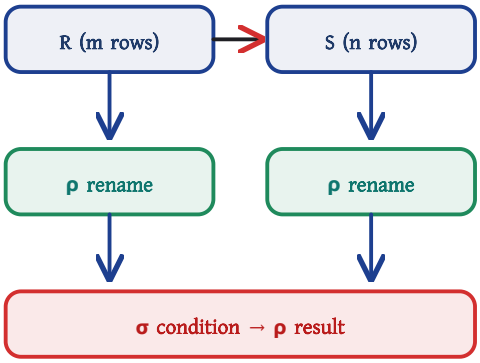
inside-out evaluation

Exam trap ✍️ the classical pair: A paper offers `σ name (Students)` and `π dept (Students)`. The first is a **type error**: *name* is an attribute, not a predicate, so σ needs a **condition** while π needs a **list of attributes**. And "π removes duplicates" is true of **RA** — plain SQL's `SELECT` keeps duplicates unless you write `DISTINCT`.

3 Product, Rename and Join — and Translating to SQL

The join formula: **θ-join** $R \bowtie_{A=\theta B} S \equiv \sigma_{A=\theta B}(R \times S)$ · **natural join** $R \bowtie S$ joins on every attribute the two relations share **by name**, then drops the duplicate copy.
Why ρ exists: a relation may not carry two attributes of the same name, so `Emp × Emp` is illegal until one copy is renamed — which is also why **every self-join needs two aliases**.

Memory trick: "**Product first, then pick.**" That one sentence gives you the join, the semi-join and every θ-join you will be asked to expand. A `WHERE`-clause query *looks* like "join first, filter after" — the optimiser silently reorders it into exactly this shape.



m × n rows, then only the pairs that pass

join = product + selection

English question	Relational algebra	SQL
Employees paid over 50 000	`σ salary>50000 (Emp)`	`SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE salary > 50000`
Only names and salaries	`π name,salary (Emp)`	`SELECT name, salary FROM Emp`
All CSE students	`σ dept='CSE'(Students)`	`… WHERE dept='CSE'`
Salary renamed to pay	`ρ pay/salary (Emp)`	`SELECT salary AS pay`
Students of the CSE department	`Students ⋈ Dept`	`… JOIN Dept ON …`

Feature	Relational algebra	SQL
Nature	**theoretical** foundation	**practical**, what users and apps write
Style	procedural — say *how*	**declarative** — say only *what*
Duplicates	none (set theory); π removes them	kept unless `DISTINCT` is written
"Paid over 50 000"	`σ salary>50000 (Emp)`	`SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE salary>50000`
Optimisation	rewrites are exactly equal relations	the optimiser **converts SQL into an RA tree**, then picks the cheapest equivalent one

Exam trap: RA works on **sets**, SQL on **bags**, so the same question may return different row counts from the two languages — a deliberate, examinable difference, not a bug. And because SQL is declarative the user does not choose the order of operations: the optimiser does, by pushing selections down towards the leaves so the huge product never happens.

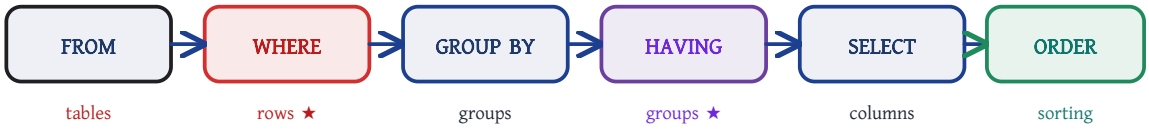
4 SQL Command Types and the Order Clauses Run In

Family	Full name	Commands	Acts on
DDL	Data Definition Language	CREATE, ALTER, DROP, TRUNCATE	**structure**
DML	Data Manipulation Language	SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE (also MERGE)	**rows**
DCL	Data Control Language	GRANT, REVOKE	**privileges**
TCL	Transaction Control Language	COMMIT, ROLLBACK, SAVEPOINT	**transactions**

Command	Data	Structure	WHERE allowed?	Family
DROP TABLE	**all rows gone**	**gone**	no	DDL
DELETE	matching rows gone	**kept**	**yes**	DML
TRUNCATE	all rows gone	**kept**	no	DDL
ALTER	kept	**changed**	no	DDL

```
SELECT   name, salary          -- 5
FROM     Employees             -- 1
WHERE    salary > 50000       -- 2
GROUP BY dept_id              -- 3
HAVING   COUNT(*) > 3        -- 4
ORDER BY salary DESC;         -- 6

INSERT INTO Students (id, name, dept) VALUES (1, 'Alice', 'CSE');
UPDATE Employees SET salary = salary * 1.10 WHERE dept = 'IT';
DELETE FROM Students WHERE id = 1;   -- WHERE makes DELETE selective
```



the order the clauses *run* in — not the order you write them

Exam trap: **WHERE filters rows *before* grouping; HAVING filters groups *after* it.** That is the whole difference, and only HAVING may use an aggregate such as `HAVING COUNT(*) > 5`.

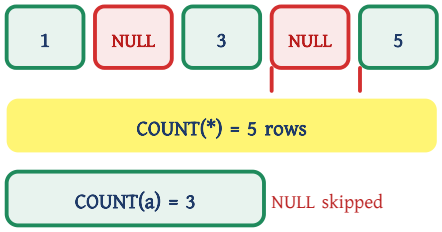
Memory trick + good to know: **"Where before, having after."** *W*here comes *W*hen rows are still rows. `HAVING` without `GROUP BY` is legal too: the whole table is one group, so `SELECT COUNT(*) FROM Emp HAVING COUNT(*) > 5` returns either one number or nothing.

5 Aggregate Functions and the NULL Rules

Aggregate	Returns	NULL inside the column	Empty set
COUNT(*)	number of **rows**	**counts them anyway**	0
COUNT(col)	number of non-NULL values of col	skipped	0
SUM / AVG(col)	total / mean of the non-NULL values	**skipped — never read as 0**	NULL
MIN / MAX(col)	smallest / largest non-NULL value	skipped	NULL

> only COUNT(*) sees NULL

Worked example 1 ✍ COUNT: `T(a)` holds `1, NULL, 3, NULL, 5`.
`SELECT COUNT(*), COUNT(a) FROM T;` → **5, 3**
COUNT(*) counts *rows*, so the two NULL rows are counted; **COUNT(a)** counts *values of a*, and a NULL value is not a value.



same five rows, two answers

the same five rows, two counts

Worked example 2 ✍ AVG: `R(score)` holds `10, NULL, 20`.
`SELECT AVG(score) FROM R;` → (10 + 20) / 2 = **15**
Every aggregate except `COUNT(*)` ignores NULL; reading it as 0 would give 10 — the **wrong** answer.

Worked example 3 ✍ GROUP BY + HAVING:
`Sales(region, amount)` = ('N',100), ('N',200), ('S',50), ('S',70), ('E',300)
`SELECT region, SUM(amount) FROM Sales GROUP BY region HAVING SUM(amount) > 150;`
Sums: N = 300, S = 120, E = 300. Only N and E pass 150 → **2 rows**.

Exam traps ✍ three of them: **1.** `AVG` over `10, NULL, 20` is **15**, not 10 — NULL is **unknown**, not zero. **2.** `COUNT(*)` on an empty table is 0, but `AVG`, `SUM`, `MIN` and `MAX` return NULL. **3.** A predicate on NULL is **unknown, never true**, so `WHERE a > 0` drops those rows silently.

Memory trick: "**Star sees every row; a column sees only real values.**" The asterisk stands for the whole tuple, so a row that exists is counted even when one of its values is missing. Read `COUNT(*)` as "count the rows", `COUNT(col)` as "count the answers".

6 The Six SQL Joins, Row by Row

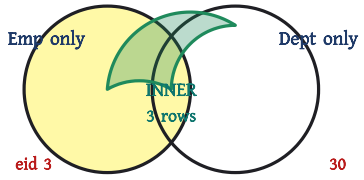
Emp(eid, dept_id)

eid	dept_id
1	10
2	20
3	NULL
4	10

Dept(dept_id, name)

dept_id	name
10	IT
20	HR
30	Finance

Join	Keeps	Rows
INNER	matches only	**3**
LEFT	all of Emp	**4**
RIGHT	all of Dept	**4**
FULL OUTER	all of both	**5**
CROSS	every pair	**12**
SELF	itself, aliased	rows & mgrs



FULL OUTER = 3 + 1 + 1 = 5

the three regions, and the row counts

INNER JOIN ✍️: `SELECT e.eid, d.name FROM Emp e JOIN Dept d ON e.dept_id = d.dept_id;`
eid 1 → 10 IT · eid 2 → 20 HR · eid 4 → 10 IT. eid 3 has NULL, and **NULL = 10 is not true**, so it is dropped; dept 30 has no employee. → **3 rows**

LEFT and RIGHT JOIN ✍️: **LEFT** = 3 matches + the unmatched employee padded → **4 rows**: (1,IT) (2,HR) (3,NULL) (4,IT). **RIGHT** = 3 matches + the unmatched department padded → **4 rows**: (1,IT) (2,HR) (4,IT) (NULL,Finance).

FULL OUTER and CROSS JOIN ✍️: FULL OUTER = 3 matching pairs + 1 unmatched *Emp* row (eid 3) + 1 unmatched *Dept* row (30 Finance) = 3 + 1 + 1 = **5 rows**; the formula is **INNER + LEFT-only + RIGHT-only**. CROSS JOIN is 4 rows × 3 rows = **12 rows**, every row of one table against every row of the other with no condition at all; in general $m \times n$, so two 3-row tables give **9**.

SELF JOIN: A relation joined to **itself** under two aliases, to relate rows inside one table — an employee to her manager. Give *Emp* two more columns, `name` and `mgr_id` (the manager's `eid`), then:
`SELECT a.name AS emp, b.name AS mgr FROM Emp a JOIN Emp b ON a.mgr_id = b.eid;`
Two aliases are **mandatory**: without them the condition would compare a column with itself.

Exam trap ✍️ the NULL one: An employee with a NULL `dept_id` is in **no** inner-join and **no** right-join result; it survives a **LEFT** and a **FULL OUTER** join, padded with NULLs. "Why did my row disappear?" → because **NULL never equals anything**, so the ON condition is unknown, not true.

Memory trick: Read the keyword as a promise about the **first-named** table. **LEFT**: keep everything on the left, pad the right. **RIGHT**: swap the word. **FULL OUTER**: keep everything on both sides. **INNER**: keep only what agrees. **CROSS**: no promise at all.

7 Join Patterns, Subqueries and Where the Rest Lives

Pattern: every department, including those with no employees: The default join drops them, so ask for them with `LEFT JOIN` and count the **child** column, not *.

```
SELECT d.dept_name, COUNT(e.emp_id) AS employee_count
FROM   Department d
LEFT JOIN Employee e ON e.dept_id = d.dept_id
GROUP BY d.dept_id, d.dept_name
ORDER BY employee_count DESC;
```

Exam traps ✍ two counts, and WHERE that kills a LEFT JOIN: `COUNT(e.emp_id)` skips the NULLs the outer join produced and correctly gives **0** for an empty department, while `COUNT(*)` counts the padded row and wrongly gives **1**; grouping by `dept_id` as well as `dept_name` keeps two departments that share a name apart. And a condition on the **right** table placed in `WHERE` is evaluated *after* the join and discards the padded rows, quietly turning your LEFT JOIN into an INNER JOIN — put it in `ON` instead.

Three kinds of subquery: **Scalar** — one value used in a comparison: `WHERE salary > (SELECT AVG(salary) FROM Emp)`. **IN / EXISTS** — a set, or true/false: `WHERE id IN (SELECT emp_id FROM Emp)`. **Correlated** — references the outer row, so it is re-evaluated **once per outer row**: `WHERE e2.dept_id = e.dept_id`.

```
SELECT MAX(salary) AS second_highest        -- 2nd highest DISTINCT salary
FROM   Employee
WHERE  salary < (SELECT MAX(salary) FROM Employee);    -- NULL if there is none
-- and, above the average of the employee's OWN department:
SELECT e.name, e.salary, d.dept_name
FROM   Employee e JOIN Department d ON d.dept_id = e.dept_id
WHERE  e.salary > ( SELECT AVG(e2.salary) FROM Employee e2
                    WHERE e2.dept_id = e.dept_id );
```

Exam traps ✍ three of them: **1.** The correlated subquery runs **once per outer row**, giving *e*'s *own* department average; a derived table pre-computing each average is usually the faster plan. **2.** The second-highest query uses <, not ≤, so it is right when the top salary repeats, and gives NULL when all salaries are equal. **3.** `NOT IN (subquery)` returns **no rows** if the subquery holds one NULL — prefer `NOT EXISTS`.

Where the rest of this chapter lives: **Functional dependencies, 1NF–BCNF, normalisation** → db3. **File organisation, primary and secondary indexes, B+ trees, cost-based optimisation** — which index makes which algebra tree cheap → db4. **Transactions, ACID, isolation, concurrency, recovery** → db5. **Constraints and triggers** sit one line below this one on the syllabus and were covered with the data models — db1.

Night-Before-the-Exam Sheet

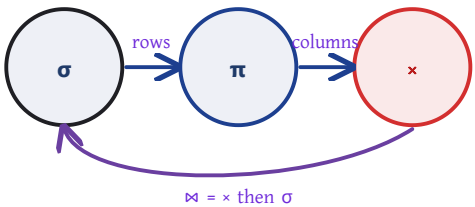
Fact sheet:

σ = **rows** (SQL's WHERE)	π = **columns** (SQL's SELECT list)
ρ = rename · × = every row with every row	Join = `σ(R × S)`
DDL: CREATE, ALTER, DROP, TRUNCATE	DML: SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE
DCL: GRANT, REVOKE	TCL: COMMIT, ROLLBACK, SAVEPOINT
DROP kills structure and data	DELETE / TRUNCATE keep structure
Run order: FROM → WHERE → GROUP BY → HAVING → SELECT → ORDER BY	WHERE filters rows **before** grouping
HAVING filters groups **after** it	COUNT(*) counts rows, NULLs included
COUNT(col) counts non-NULL only	AVG of 10, NULL, 20 = **15**
Other aggregates skip NULL	NULL never equals anything in a join
FULL OUTER = INNER + left-only + right-only	Six joins: INNER, LEFT, RIGHT, FULL, CROSS, SELF
CROSS JOIN = m × n rows	Zero-staff departments: `COUNT(e.emp_id)`

Top 12 one-liners for MCQs

1. Selection σ filters rows; projection π filters columns
2. Rename ρ renames; × pairs every row with every row
3. A join is a product plus a selection
4. DDL · DML · DCL · TCL — four families, four purposes
5. **DROP** removes structure and data together
6. **DELETE** and **TRUNCATE** both keep the structure
7. WHERE before grouping, HAVING after grouping
8. Only HAVING may use an aggregate
9. On 1, NULL, 3, NULL, 5: COUNT(*)=5, COUNT(a)=3
10. AVG of 10, NULL, 20 is 15, never 10
11. NULL never equals anything in a join condition
12. Zero-staff departments need `COUNT(e.emp_id)`

Top traps: σ and π swapped · π removes duplicates but SELECT does not · DROP vs DELETE vs TRUNCATE · WHERE confused with HAVING · `AVG` reading NULL as 0 · expecting a NULL-department employee in an inner join · `COUNT(*)` for zero-employee counts · a WHERE on the right table turning a LEFT JOIN into an INNER JOIN.



two primitives make every join

All tricks together: Sigma picks rows, pi picks columns · product first, then pick · where before, having after · star sees every row, a column sees only real values · keep everything on the left, pad the right · join by an alias, never by the bare table name.

✓ Practice MCQs (exam pattern, 10 marks)

1. Which SQL command removes a table's structure together with all its data?
(a) DELETE (b) TRUNCATE
(c) ALTER (d) DROP

2. Which clause filters groups after `GROUP BY` has been applied?
(a) HAVING (b) WHERE
(c) ORDER BY (d) DISTINCT

3. Which relational algebra operator keeps the tuples that satisfy a condition?
(a) Projection (π) (b) Rename (ρ)
(c) Selection (σ) (d) Cartesian product (×)

4. `T` has one column `a` with rows 1, NULL, 3, NULL, 5. `SELECT COUNT(*), COUNT(a) FROM T;` gives:
(a) 3 and 3 (b) 5 and 3
(c) 5 and 5 (d) 3 and 5

5. `R.score` holds 10, NULL, 20. `SELECT AVG(score) FROM R;` returns:
(a) 10 (b) 15
(c) 20 (d) NULL

6. With `Emp` = (1,10),(2,20),(3,NULL),(4,10) and `Dept` = (10,'IT'),(20,'HR'),(30,'Finance'), the INNER JOIN on `dept_id` returns:
(a) 3 rows (b) 4 rows
(c) 5 rows (d) 12 rows

7. The same data with a FULL OUTER JOIN returns:
(a) 3 rows (b) 4 rows
(c) 5 rows (d) 6 rows

8. `Sales` = ('N',100),('N',200),('S',50),('S',70),('E',300). `GROUP BY region HAVING SUM(amount) > 150` returns:
(a) 1 row (b) 3 rows
(c) 5 rows (d) 2 rows

9. Listing every department with its employee count, including empty ones, needs:
(a) COUNT(*) (b) COUNT(e.emp_id)
(c) COUNT(d.dept_name) (d) SUM(e.salary)

10. In SQL, relational algebra's selection σ corresponds to:
(a) the WHERE clause (b) the SELECT list
(c) GROUP BY (d) ORDER BY

Answer key → 1-d · 2-a · 3-c · 4-b · 5-b · 6-a · 7-c · 8-d · 9-b · 10-a

Written question: Explain the fundamental operations of relational algebra on `Students(id, name, dept)` and `Courses(cid, name)`. Distinguish DDL, DML, DCL and TCL, and say exactly what DROP, DELETE, TRUNCATE and ALTER each do. Then, for `Emp` = (1,10),(2,20),(3,NULL),(4,10) and `Dept` = (10,'IT'),(20,'HR'),(30,'Finance'), give the row count of INNER, LEFT, RIGHT, FULL OUTER and CROSS JOIN and explain why employee 3 never appears in an inner join. 10 marks

1. **RA operators (2)** — **σ** keeps rows meeting a condition, **π** keeps columns and removes duplicates, **ρ** renames, **×** pairs every row of one relation with every row of another (2 × 2 = **4**), **∪ − ∩** are the set operators, and **⋈** is derived as `σ(R × S)`. 2
2. **Command families (2)** — **DDL** (Definition) on **structure**: CREATE, ALTER, DROP, TRUNCATE. **DML** (Manipulation) on **rows**: SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE. **DCL** (Control) on **privileges**: GRANT, REVOKE. **TCL** (Transaction Control): COMMIT, ROLLBACK, SAVEPOINT. 2
3. **The four commands (2)** — **DROP** removes structure *and* data; **DELETE** removes rows, optionally by `WHERE`, keeping the structure; **TRUNCATE** removes all rows, keeps the structure, allows no `WHERE`; **ALTER** changes the structure and keeps the data. 2
4. **Row counts (1)** — INNER **3**, LEFT **4**, RIGHT **4**, FULL OUTER **5** = 3 + 1 + 1, CROSS 4 × 3 = **12**. 1
5. **Why employee 3 disappears (2)** — its `dept_id` is NULL and **NULL = 10 is unknown, not true**; an inner join keeps a row only when the ON condition is **true**. It survives LEFT and FULL OUTER, padded with NULLs. 2
6. **Where vs having (1)** — `WHERE` filters **rows before** grouping; `HAVING` filters **groups after** `GROUP BY`, and is the only one that may use an aggregate. 1

Before the exam ✓

- ✓ Can name σ, π, ρ, × with an example each
- ✓ Can write a join as σ(R × S) and explain ρ
- ✓ Can place any command in DDL, DML, DCL or TCL
- ✓ Can say what DROP, DELETE, TRUNCATE, ALTER do
- ✓ Can count the rows of all six joins
- ✓ Can state the COUNT(*) / AVG-with-NULL rules